

Let's suppose that the view that there are immaterial souls is true. Then your roommate is (either wholly or in part) an immaterial soul.

We've now encountered the main arguments for the view
that you are, either entirely or in part, an immaterial
thing.

We have already encountered two kinds of arguments
against that view.

The first are the “easy arguments” for materialism. Those seem to be more of a problem for the simple believer in immaterial souls than for the fusion believer in immaterial souls.

The second is the argument that we should not believe in souls for the same reason we don't believe in fairies: there is no good evidence for their existence. That might be countered with the knowledge argument or the conceivability argument.

Let's look at some others.

Here is something that seems possible: last night, the soul connected to your roommate's body could have been swapped out for a different one which has exactly the same apparent memories and personality.

You would, it seems, have no way of telling whether this happened. So you have no evidence that it did not happen. So, you do not know whether you have the same roommate as you did yesterday.

But of course you do know this. So the view that there
are immaterial souls must be false.

More dramatically, the soul attached to your own body could have been swapped out last night. It seems that you would have no way of knowing whether this happened. After all, the new soul (which you are) could have been given the same personality and apparent memories as the old soul.

So you do not know whether you have been attached to this body for more than a day. But of course you do know that you have been attached to this body for more than a day. So, the view that there are immaterial souls must be false.

Call this the argument from soul-swapping. How should the believer in immaterial souls respond?

Here is another related argument.

Let's call Ferdinand before the accident "Ferdinand-" and Ferdinand after the accident "Ferdinand+".

Psychology-swapping

Ferdinand is a combination of a soul and a body. Suppose that Ferdinand suffers an accident which entirely changes his psychology. He has none of his former memories, and none of his former personality traits. He used to be very selfish; he's now very generous. He used to be best friends with Jane; now he finds Jane annoying, and prefers to spend time with Maria.

Suppose that Ferdinand- used to occasionally take some cash from your wallet. Ferdinand+ would never do this. Would you be right to blame Ferdinand+ for the actions of Ferdinand-?

It seems plausible that you would not blame Ferdinand+
for these actions. Remember: he has complete amnesia,
and his behavior and attitudes now are entirely different.

But if they are different people, it looks like our believer in immaterial souls answers to the survival question are incorrect. For there is no obvious reason why the numerically same soul could not be attached to Ferdinand's body throughout this process.

This argument relies on the idea that sufficient differences in psychology are enough to make for a difference in personal identity. Note that while this also rules out M+S, it does not rule out P+S.

Another 'swapping' argument attempts to show that any answer to the survival question that involves immaterial souls is false.

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You would, it seems, have no way of telling whether this happened. So you have no evidence that it did not happen. So, you do not know whether you have the same roommate as you did yesterday. But of course you do know this; so soul theories must be false.

More dramatically, the soul attached to your own body could have been swapped out last night (or one second ago). It seems that you would have no way of knowing whether this happened. After all, the new soul (which you are) could have been given the same personality and apparent memories as the old soul.

Does this suggest that something is wrong with answers to the survival question which involve immaterial souls?

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